

really need anti-virus protection too to stay safe online. Avira Antivir (www.free-av.com), Avast antivirus (www.avast.com) or AVG Free (<http://free.grisoft.com>) will all keep home users safe from a range of malware for no charge at all.

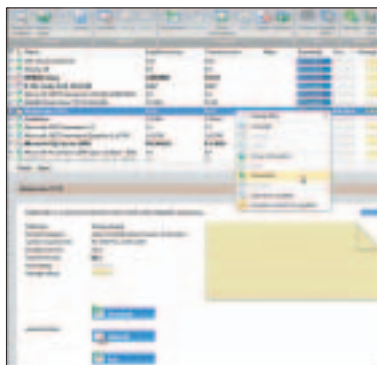
The Windows Vista Recycle Bin sees an impressive new icon, but we'd rather Microsoft had addressed a more significant flaw – namely its inability to securely wipe files. If a Mac user wants to get rid of a confidential file forever then they simply click Secure Empty Trash and it'll be overwritten in such a way that snoopers with undelete software won't be able to recover a thing. Windows users must simply choose the Empty Recycle Bin and hope no-one else gets access to their system, and that's not good enough. Doubtless Microsoft will get around to adding this eventually, but in the meantime you can fix the problem for yourself by installing Eraser (www.heidi.ie).

File encryption is annoyingly reserved for the Windows Vista Business, Enterprise and Ultimate editions. Microsoft apparently believes that home users don't have any confidential data worth protecting. Still, don't complain, just download a free copy of Truecrypt (www.truecrypt.org). It can create virtual encrypted drives that will keep all your most private files safe from snoopers.

Backup concerns

Microsoft promised us a shiny new backup tool in Windows Vista, and we got one – but it didn't entirely live up to expectations. You can ask the utility to back up all the pictures on your drive, for instance, but can't tell it to pick only the images in a particular folder. That means it's almost impossible to use the tool for quick, selective backups, and that's a real disappointment.

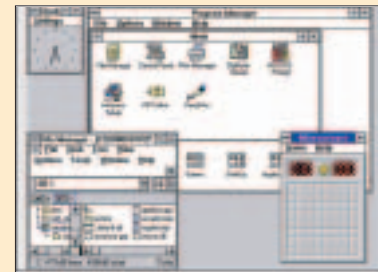
Windows Vista also delivered Shadow Copies (automatic backups made at the file level) and Windows Complete PC Backup to make an exact copy of your entire drive. But these were



Updatestar works like Windows Update for your other applications, telling you when new updates are available

The Windows legacy

The real problem with Windows Vista is backward compatibility – in other words, the need to ensure it runs your old software. A little of this is a good thing, of course; if Windows Vista wouldn't run your copy of Microsoft Office 2003 then



Windows' future looks bleak for old apps

you'd rightly be very annoyed. But take backward compatibility too far and there's a price to pay. One reason Windows can perform poorly is that it's become overweight, a rickety structure full of patches and design compromises, all so that it can run 15-year-old programs and games.

There's some hope the next version of Windows will see a complete rewrite, drastically improving performance at the expense of breaking old software. If you want a taste of things to come, the best you can do is move to 64-bit Windows Vista. You may have trouble finding drivers for some hardware, but it does take full advantage of modern processors, providing better performance, improved stability, and can use up to 128GB of memory.

only available if you splashed out on the more expensive editions of Vista. Regular Home Premium users would have to do without.

Fortunately there are several ways around these problems, especially if you apply some lateral thinking. Why not make use of Windows Easy Transfer, for instance? Sure, it's supposed to be used when you're moving your settings directly from an old PC to a new one. But so what? The program still effectively lets you save copies of your email, favourites, address book, Windows settings or specific folders to a blank DVD, a USB memory key or a network or external hard disk. And if there's a disaster you can use these copies to restore everything. Click Start, type Windows Easy Transfer and press Enter on your keyboard to see how this works.

For real control you'll want to install something more powerful, though, and there are plenty of free tools around. Cobian